🔑 AWESOME CYBER SECURITY HEAVEN · REALM DOSSIER · 2026 EDITION

The Vault

Secrets, Credentials & Password Security Tools

17	254,031	88%	14
FREE TOOLS	COMBINED STARS	ON GITHUB	ACTIVE IN 2026

Intro: Where secrets live and leak — find them before attackers do, and keep the new ones safe.

Deep-research edition. Every entry re-verified and enriched with live GitHub statistics (stars, first release, last push, license, language) pulled 2026-10-17 via the GitHub API, plus per-realm field intelligence. Tool profiles rank the realm's most-adopted projects and note who uses each tool and the commercial product it replaces; the full inventory keeps every curated entry.

Part of Awesome Cyber Security Heaven — **444 curated free tools across 14 realms**.

github.com/RanaKhan77/awesome-cyber-security-heaven
CC0 · 2026-10-17

01 Realm Intelligence

live GitHub census · 2026-10-17

17	15	254,031	14	20,382	2011
CURATED TOOLS	ON GITHUB	COMBINED STARS	PUSHED 2026	MEDIAN STARS	OLDEST ENTRY

REALM BRIEF

Intro: Where secrets live and leak — find them before attackers do, and keep the new ones safe.

FIELD INTELLIGENCE (AI-ASSISTED)

The Vault realm of secrets, credentials, and password security tools includes 17 curated entries, with 88% hosted on GitHub, dating back to an oldest entry from December 16, 2011. Adoption is heavily concentrated in top tools: HashiCorp Vault leads with 36,400 stars, followed by gitleaks (30,100), KeePassXC (29,300), trufflehog (28,500), and hashcat (27,000), while the remaining 12 tools have far lower individual visibility. Maintenance activity shows strong recent momentum, with 14 of the 17 tools receiving code pushes in 2026, leaving only LaZagne as a quiet classic with no 2026 updates. The toolset's language mix is dominated by Go (5 entries), C (3), and Python (2), with a license split that includes 3 MIT, 3 Apache-2.0, and 9 tools with other or no specified licenses, reflecting a mix of open-source permissive and unregulated distribution models.

Synthesized by seed-2-0-mini over the live census: stars, first-release years, push activity and project claims pulled from the GitHub API on 2026-10-17. Human-curated realm, AI-summarized numbers.

01 The Adoption Map

who the community actually stars

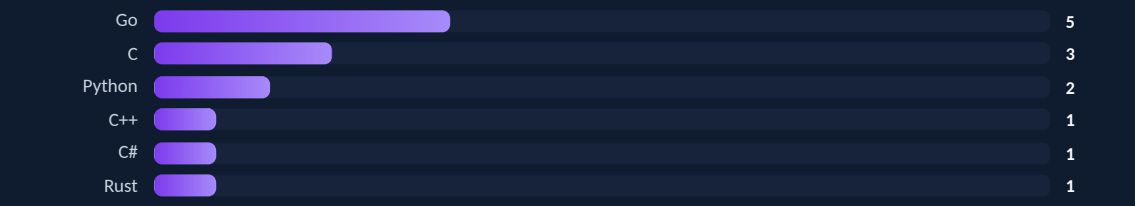
TOP TOOLS BY GITHUB STARS



MOST-FORKED — REAL-WORLD REUSE SIGNAL



LANGUAGE MIX — GITHUB-HOSTED ENTRIES



01 Generations & Momentum

the realm's age structure

THE FOUNDERS — OLDEST TRACKED ENTRIES

John the Ripper	2011-12-16
LaZagne	2015-02-16
HashiCorp Vault	2015-02-25
SOPS	2015-08-13
Bitwarden	2015-11-23

THE NEWCOMERS — NEWEST GITHUB ARRIVALS

noseyparker	2022-11
keyFinder	2019-08
age	2019-05
hardened_malloc	2018-08
gitleaks	2018-01

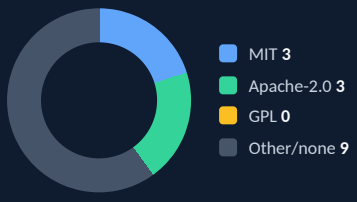
CREATION ERAS — WHEN THE REALM WAS BUILT

2008-2012	2013-2016	2017-2020	2021-2026
1	8	5	1

QUIET CLASSICS (NO 2026 PUSH, STILL THE STANDARD)

LaZagne

LICENSE MIX — GITHUB-HOSTED ENTRIES



02 Tool Profiles — the heavyweights

full-page dossiers · ranked by adoption

Each heavyweight gets a full dossier: live GitHub census (stars, forks, first-release year, last push, license, language), the project's own claim, our curator's note, **who uses it and which commercial product it replaces**, and its star weight against the realm's #1.

Profiles are ordered by GitHub adoption (stars). Non-GitHub entries follow, alphabetically. Flagship marks the realm's top 8 by stars.

01 HashiCorp Vault

github.com/hashicorp/vault

★ FLAGSHIP PICK ACTIVE 2026

star weight vs realm #1



★ 36.4k	GITHUB STARS
4,792	FORKS
2026-10	LAST PUSH
2015	FIRST DEVELOPED
custom	LICENSE
Go	LANGUAGE

THEIR CLAIM — AS THE PROJECT STATES IT

"A tool for secrets management, encryption as a service, and privileged access management"

CURATOR'S NOTE — WHY IT EARNS A PLACE

the enterprise secrets platform: dynamic credentials, PKI, encryption-as-a-service.

WHO USES IT · WHAT IT REPLACES

Used by platform teams managing secrets at scale; the open-source alternative to cloud secret stores and CyberArk for dynamic secrets. (source-available BSL)

WHERE IT SITS — REALM TOP 8 BY STARS (▶ = THIS TOOL)



11	4,792	1,471	yes
YEARS ON GITHUB	FORKS (REUSE)	OPEN ISSUES	2026 MOMENTUM

02 gitleaks

github.com/gitleaks/gitleaks

★ FLAGSHIP PICK ACTIVE 2026

star weight vs realm #1



★ 30.1k	GITHUB STARS
2,327	FORKS
2026-09	LAST PUSH
2018	FIRST DEVELOPED
MIT	LICENSE
Go	LANGUAGE

THEIR CLAIM — AS THE PROJECT STATES IT

"Find secrets with Gitleaks 🔑"

CURATOR'S NOTE — WHY IT EARNS A PLACE

fast git-history secret scanning from pre-commit hooks to CI; the default choice for repos.

WHO USES IT · WHAT IT REPLACES

Used by DevSecOps teams scanning repos for secrets in CI; the open-source alternative to GitGuardian's paid platform.

WHERE IT SITS — REALM TOP 8 BY STARS (▶ = THIS TOOL)



8	2,327	501	yes
YEARS ON GITHUB	FORKS (REUSE)	OPEN ISSUES	2026 MOMENTUM

03 KeePassXC

github.com/keepassxreboot/keepassxc

★ FLAGSHIP PICK ACTIVE 2026

star weight vs realm #1



★ 29.3k	GITHUB STARS
1,956	FORKS
2026-10	LAST PUSH
2016	FIRST DEVELOPED
custom	LICENSE
C++	LANGUAGE

THEIR CLAIM — AS THE PROJECT STATES IT

"KeePassXC is a cross-platform community-driven port of the Windows application "KeePass Password Safe"."

CURATOR'S NOTE — WHY IT EARNS A PLACE

cross-platform, offline, no-cloud password manager — the security-community standard.

WHO USES IT · WHAT IT REPLACES

Used by security-conscious professionals storing credentials offline; the community alternative to 1Password and LastPass.

WHERE IT SITS — REALM TOP 8 BY STARS (▶ = THIS TOOL)



10	1,956	937	yes
YEARS ON GITHUB	FORKS (REUSE)	OPEN ISSUES	2026 MOMENTUM

04 trufflehog

github.com/trufflesecurity/trufflehog

★ FLAGSHIP PICK ACTIVE 2026

star weight vs realm #1



★ 28.5k	GITHUB STARS
2,644	FORKS
2026-10	LAST PUSH
2016	FIRST DEVELOPED
AGPL-3.0	LICENSE
Go	LANGUAGE

THEIR CLAIM — AS THE PROJECT STATES IT

"Find, verify, and analyze leaked credentials"

CURATOR'S NOTE — WHY IT EARNS A PLACE

deep secret scanning across git, S3, Docker images and 800+ detector types with live credential verification.

WHO USES IT · WHAT IT REPLACES

Used by security teams hunting leaked secrets across git history and object stores; the open-source alternative to commercial secret-scanning services.

WHERE IT SITS — REALM TOP 8 BY STARS (▶ = THIS TOOL)



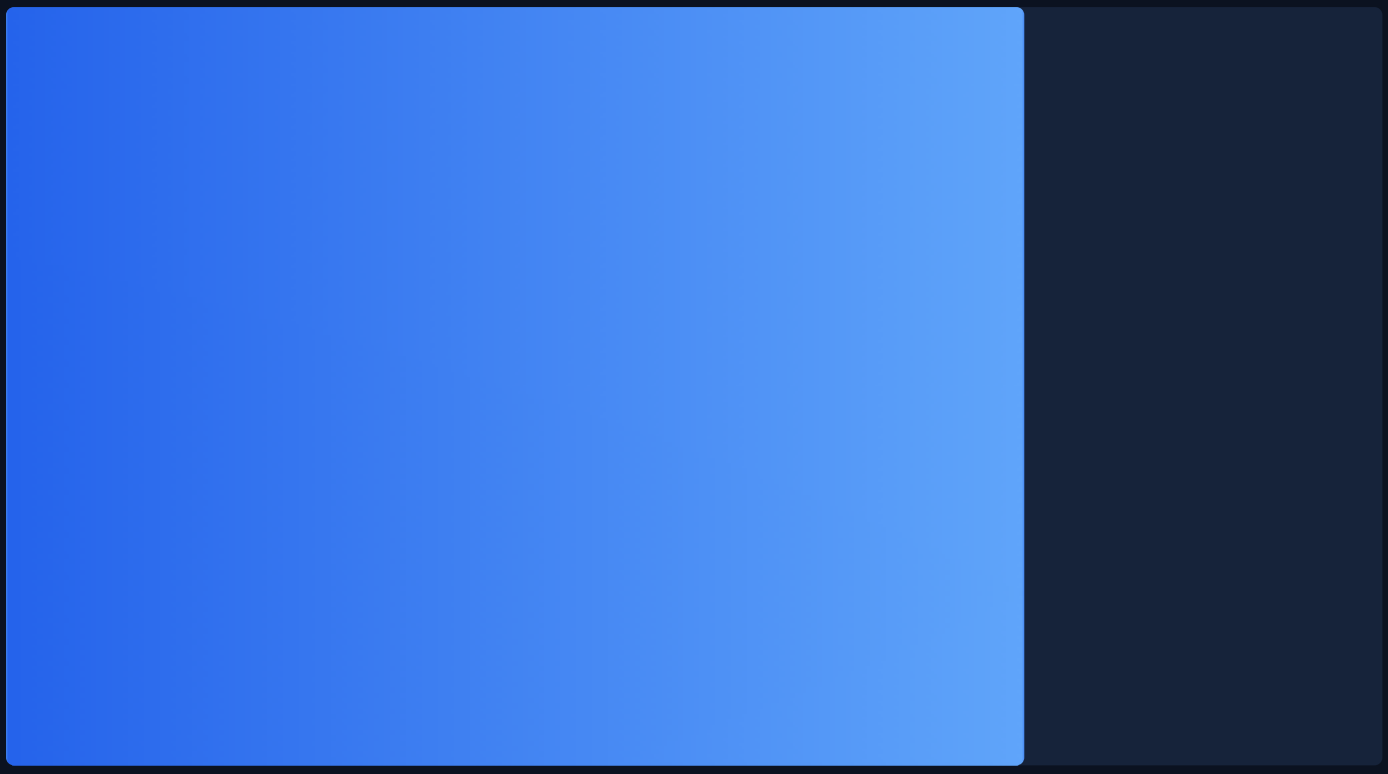
10	2,644	575	yes
YEARS ON GITHUB	FORKS (REUSE)	OPEN ISSUES	2026 MOMENTUM

05 hashcat

github.com/hashcat/hashcat

★ FLAGSHIP PICK ACTIVE 2026

star weight vs realm #1



★ 27k	GITHUB STARS
3,576	FORKS
2026-10	LAST PUSH
2015	FIRST DEVELOPED
None	LICENSE
C	LANGUAGE

THEIR CLAIM — AS THE PROJECT STATES IT

"World's fastest and most advanced password recovery utility"

CURATOR'S NOTE — WHY IT EARNS A PLACE

the world's fastest password-recovery tool; the standard for authorized password-strength audits.

WHO USES IT · WHAT IT REPLACES

Used by password auditors and DFIR teams worldwide; the cracker commercial rigs also run.

WHERE IT SITS — REALM TOP 8 BY STARS (▶ = THIS TOOL)



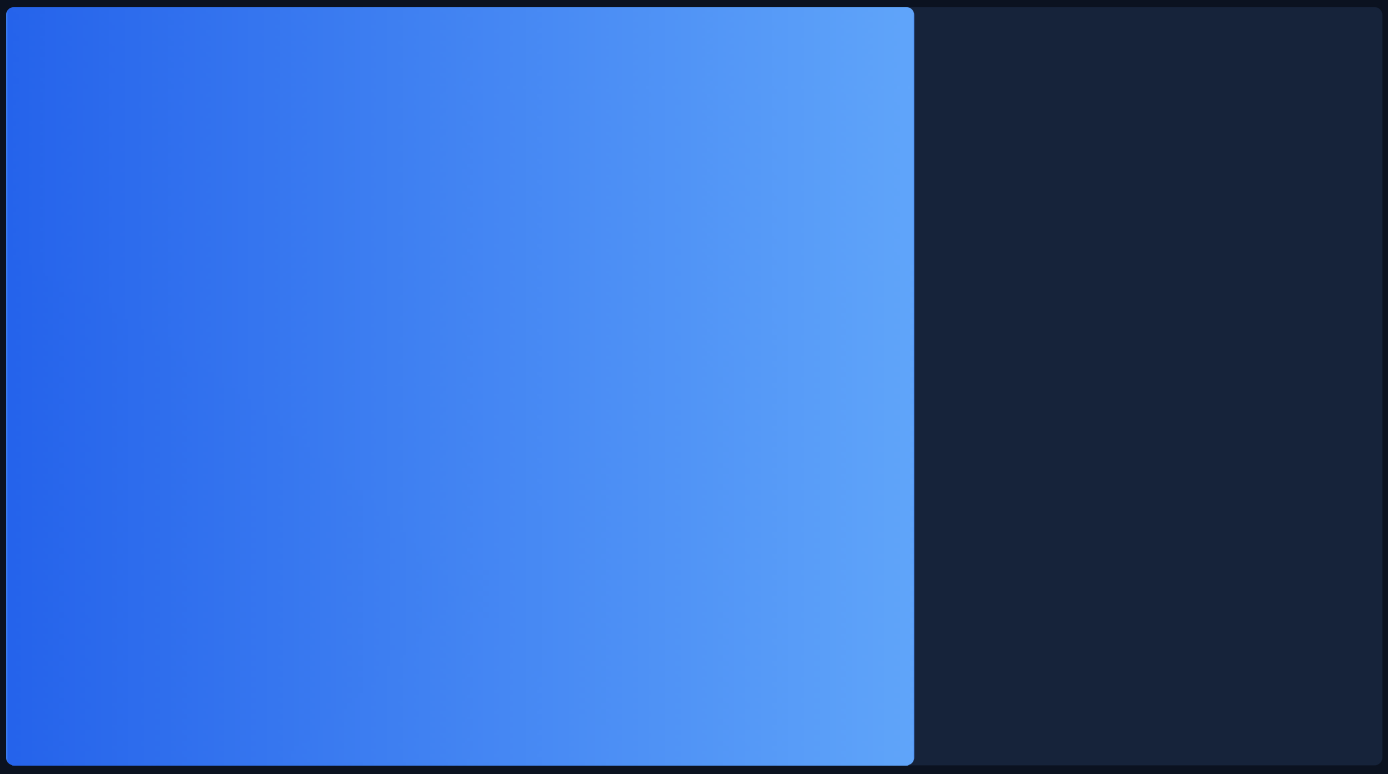
11	3,576	214	yes
YEARS ON GITHUB	FORKS (REUSE)	OPEN ISSUES	2026 MOMENTUM

06 age

github.com/FiloSottile/age

★ FLAGSHIP PICK ACTIVE 2026

star weight vs realm #1



★ 23.9k	GITHUB STARS
678	FORKS
2026-08	LAST PUSH
2019	FIRST DEVELOPED
BSD-3-Clause	LICENSE
Go	LANGUAGE

THEIR CLAIM — AS THE PROJECT STATES IT

"A simple, modern and secure encryption tool (and Go library) with small explicit keys, no config options, and UNIX-style composability."

CURATOR'S NOTE — WHY IT EARNS A PLACE

simple, modern, opinionated file-encryption tool for the post-GPG era.

WHO USES IT · WHAT IT REPLACES

Used by developers wanting simple, modern file encryption; the spiritual successor to GPG for the gitops era.

WHERE IT SITS — REALM TOP 8 BY STARS (▶ = THIS TOOL)



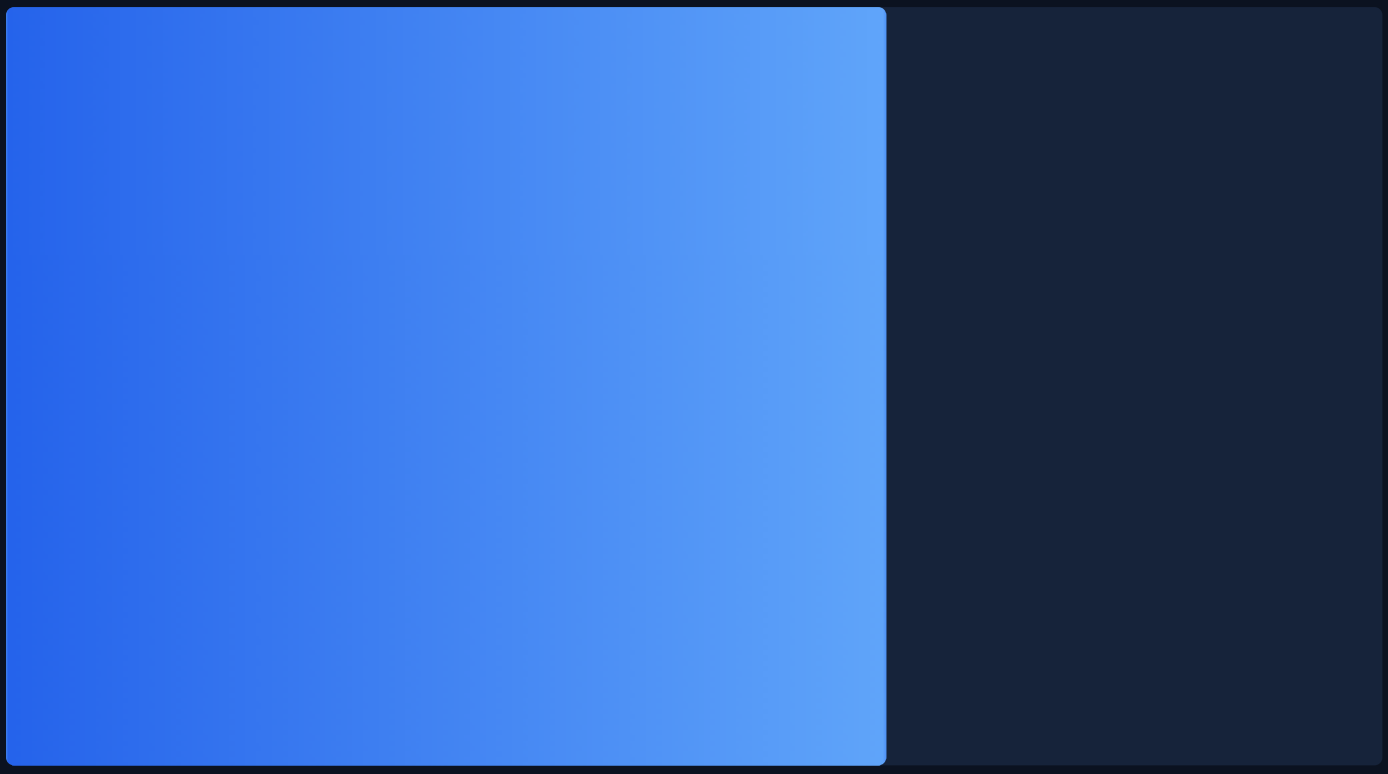
7	678	21	yes
YEARS ON GITHUB	FORKS (REUSE)	OPEN ISSUES	2026 MOMENTUM

07 SOPS

github.com/getsops/sops

★ FLAGSHIP PICK ACTIVE 2026

star weight vs realm #1



★ 23.4k	GITHUB STARS
1,099	FORKS
2026-10	LAST PUSH
2015	FIRST DEVELOPED
MPL-2.0	LICENSE
Go	LANGUAGE

THEIR CLAIM — AS THE PROJECT STATES IT

"Simple and flexible tool for managing secrets"

CURATOR'S NOTE — WHY IT EARNS A PLACE

encrypted secrets in git: edit YAML/JSON values, commit ciphertext, rotate keys.

WHO USES IT · WHAT IT REPLACES

Used by DevOps teams encrypting secrets inside config repos; the open standard for gitops-friendly secret management.

WHERE IT SITS — REALM TOP 8 BY STARS (▶ = THIS TOOL)



11	1,099	460	yes
YEARS ON GITHUB	FORKS (REUSE)	OPEN ISSUES	2026 MOMENTUM

08 Bitwarden

github.com/bitwarden/server

★ FLAGSHIP PICK
ACTIVE 2026

star weight vs realm #1



★ 20.4k	GITHUB STARS
1,802	FORKS
2026-10	LAST PUSH
2015	FIRST DEVELOPED
custom	LICENSE
C#	LANGUAGE

THEIR CLAIM — AS THE PROJECT STATES IT

"Bitwarden infrastructure/backend (API, database, Docker, etc)."

CURATOR'S NOTE — WHY IT EARNS A PLACE

open-source, sync-everywhere password management for teams and families.

WHO USES IT · WHAT IT REPLACES

Used by teams and individuals wanting open-source password management; the self-hostable alternative to commercial password SaaS.

WHERE IT SITS — REALM TOP 8 BY STARS (▶ = THIS TOOL)



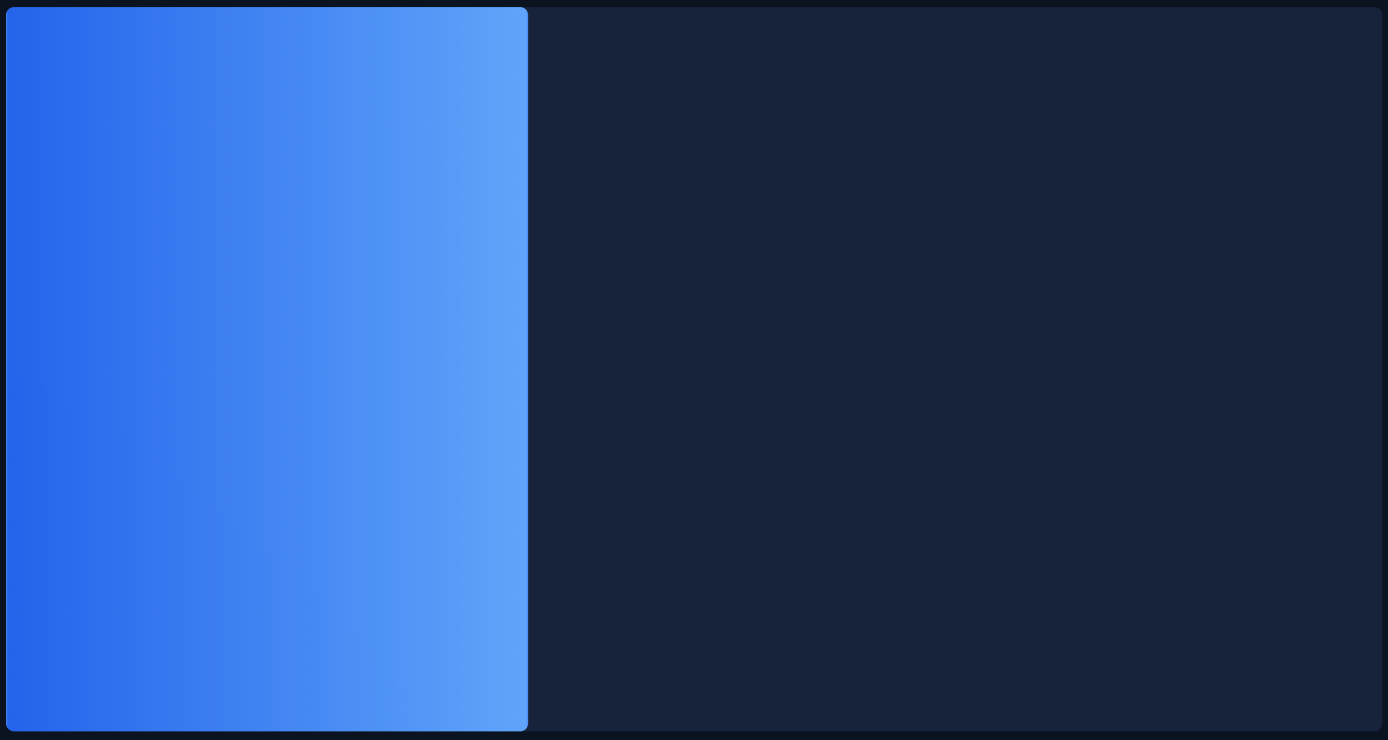
11	1,802	275	yes
YEARS ON GITHUB	FORKS (REUSE)	OPEN ISSUES	2026 MOMENTUM

09 John the Ripper

github.com/openwall/john

ACTIVE 2026

star weight vs realm #1



★ 13.8k	GITHUB STARS
2,564	FORKS
2026-10	LAST PUSH
2011	FIRST DEVELOPED
custom	LICENSE
C	LANGUAGE

THEIR CLAIM — AS THE PROJECT STATES IT

"John the Ripper jumbo - advanced offline password cracker, which supports hundreds of hash and cipher types, and runs on many operating systems, CPUs, GPUs, and even some FPGAs"

CURATOR'S NOTE — WHY IT EARNS A PLACE

the classic password auditor: hundreds of hash formats and the legendary jumbo community build.

WHO USES IT · WHAT IT REPLACES

Used by password auditors for three decades; the classic open-source cracker no pentest kit ships without.

WHERE IT SITS — REALM TOP 8 BY STARS (▶ = THIS TOOL)



15	2,564	519	yes
YEARS ON GITHUB	FORKS (REUSE)	OPEN ISSUES	2026 MOMENTUM

10 LaZagne

github.com/AlessandroZ/LaZagne

star weight vs realm #1



★ 11k	GITHUB STARS
2,125	FORKS
2025-09	LAST PUSH
2015	FIRST DEVELOPED
LGPL-3.0	LICENSE
Python	LANGUAGE

THEIR CLAIM — AS THE PROJECT STATES IT

"Credentials recovery project"

CURATOR'S NOTE — WHY IT EARNS A PLACE

audits which passwords your workstations remember — browsers, mail clients, OS stores — for authorized inventory and exposure checks only.

WHO USES IT · WHAT IT REPLACES

Used by pentesters in authorized engagements demonstrating credential exposure on compromised hosts; the classic credential-harvesting tool.

WHERE IT SITS — REALM TOP 8 BY STARS (▶ = THIS TOOL)



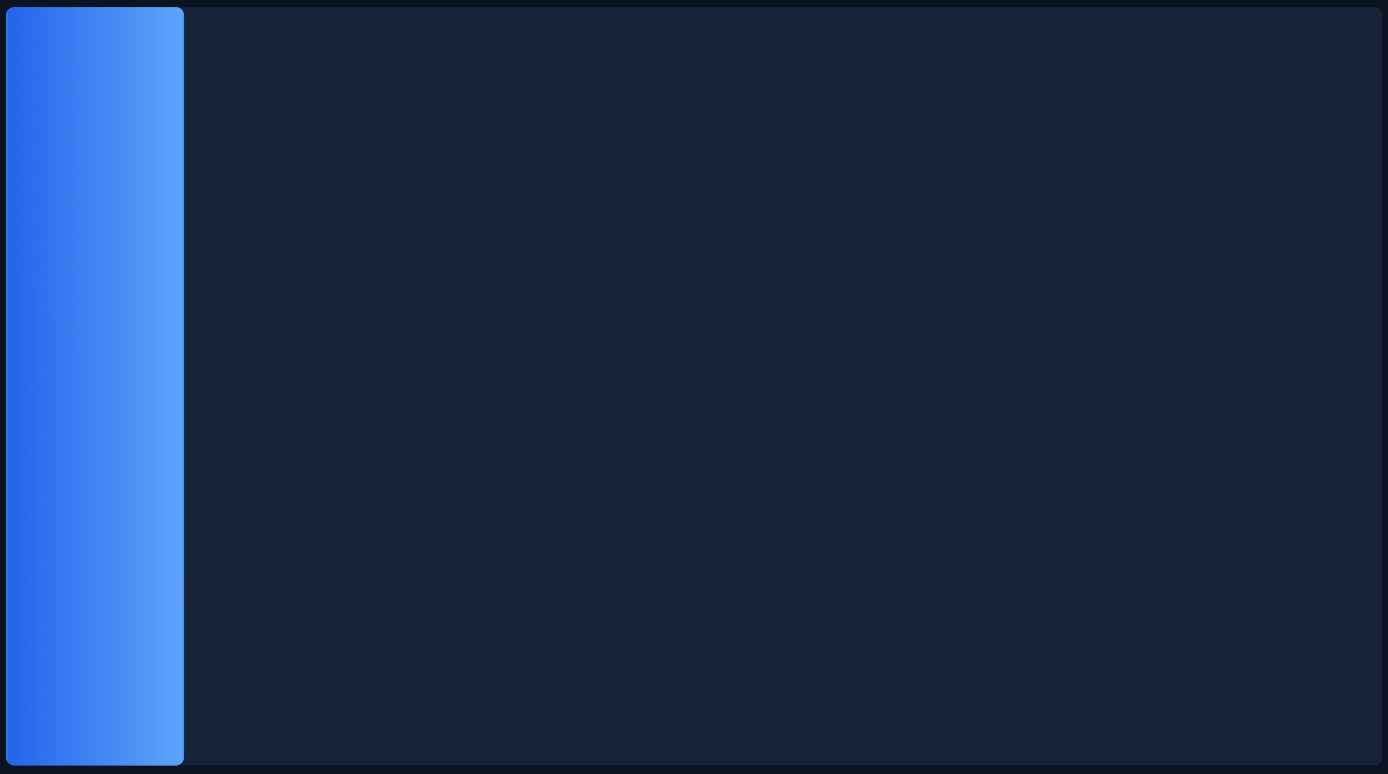
11	2,125	18	—
YEARS ON GITHUB	FORKS (REUSE)	OPEN ISSUES	2026 MOMENTUM

11 detect-secrets

ACTIVE 2026

github.com/Yelp/detect-secrets

star weight vs realm #1



★ 4.7k	GITHUB STARS
575	FORKS
2026-04	LAST PUSH
2017	FIRST DEVELOPED
Apache-2.0	LICENSE
Python	LANGUAGE

THEIR CLAIM — AS THE PROJECT STATES IT

"An enterprise friendly way of detecting and preventing secrets in code."

CURATOR'S NOTE — WHY IT EARNS A PLACE

enterprise secret scanner designed for baseline diffs and incremental CI audits.

WHO USES IT · WHAT IT REPLACES

Used by CI pipelines baseline-scanning for secrets; Yelp's open scanner that complements commercial enterprise offerings.

WHERE IT SITS — REALM TOP 8 BY STARS (▶ = THIS TOOL)



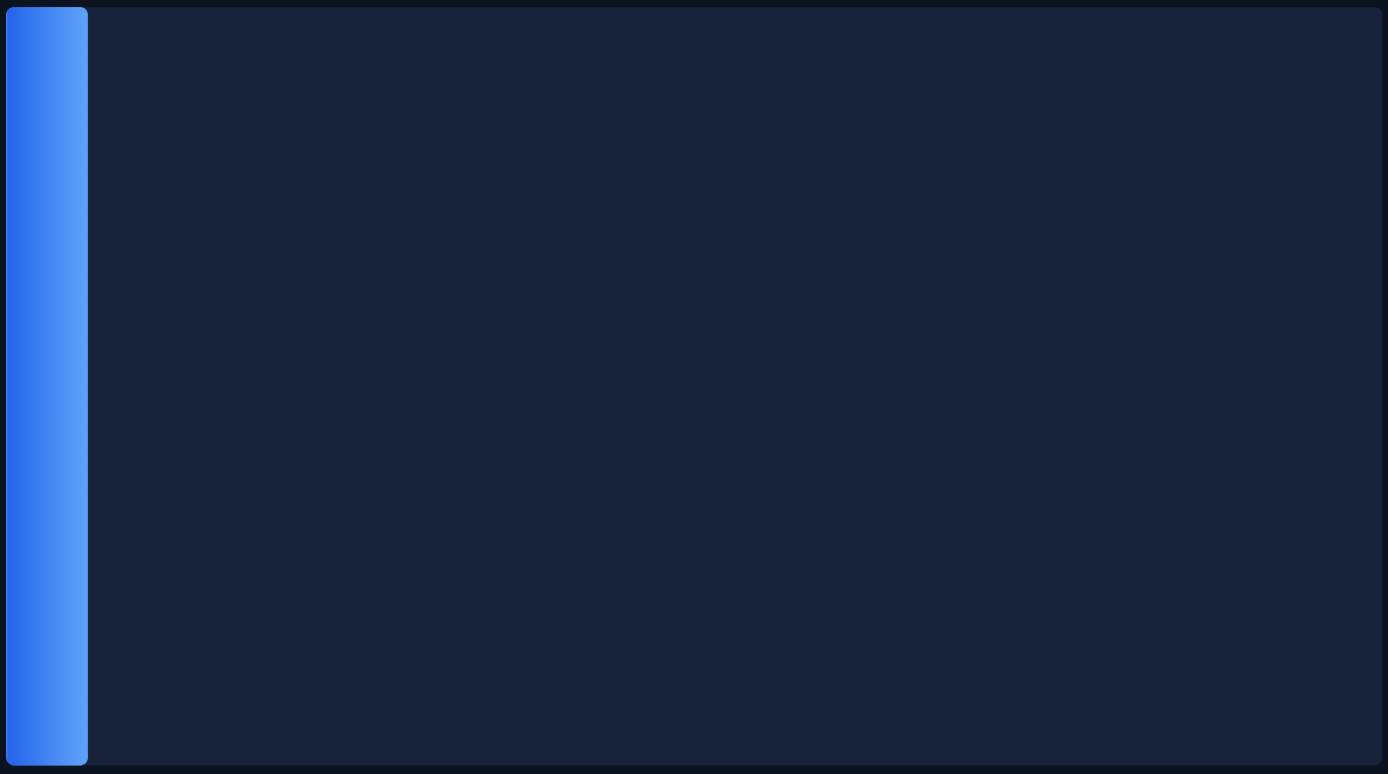
9	575	185	yes
YEARS ON GITHUB	FORKS (REUSE)	OPEN ISSUES	2026 MOMENTUM

12 noseyparker

github.com/praetorian-inc/noseyparker

ACTIVE 2026

star weight vs realm #1



★ 2.3k	GITHUB STARS
132	FORKS
2026-02	LAST PUSH
2022	FIRST DEVELOPED
Apache-2.0	LICENSE
Rust	LANGUAGE

THEIR CLAIM — AS THE PROJECT STATES IT

"Nosey Parker is a command-line tool that finds secrets and sensitive information in textual data and Git history."

CURATOR'S NOTE — WHY IT EARNS A PLACE

blazing-fast secret scanning built for huge codebases and full-history sweeps.

WHO USES IT · WHAT IT REPLACES

Used by incident responders and bug hunters scanning large corpora for secrets fast; the Rust-powered open alternative for scale.

WHERE IT SITS — REALM TOP 8 BY STARS (▶ = THIS TOOL)



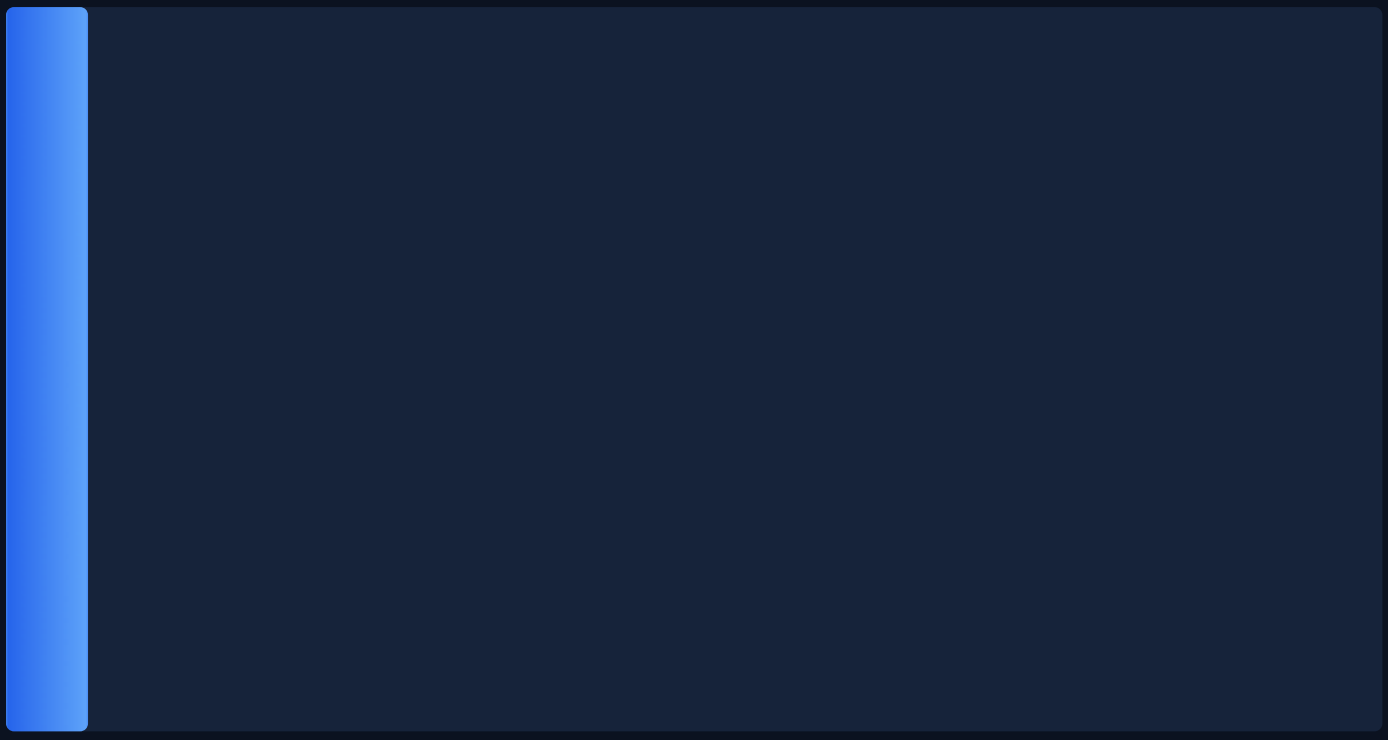
4	132	27	yes
YEARS ON GITHUB	FORKS (REUSE)	OPEN ISSUES	2026 MOMENTUM

13 hardened_malloc

github.com/GrapheneOS/hardened_malloc

ACTIVE 2026

star weight vs realm #1



★ 2k	GITHUB STARS
167	FORKS
2026-10	LAST PUSH
2018	FIRST DEVELOPED
MIT	LICENSE
C	LANGUAGE

THEIR CLAIM — AS THE PROJECT STATES IT

“Hardened allocator designed for modern systems. It has integration into Android's Bionic libc and can be used externally with musl and glibc as a dynamic library for use on other Linux-based platforms. It will gain more ”

CURATOR'S NOTE — WHY IT EARNS A PLACE

the allocator that makes exploitation harder by design; from the GrapheneOS project.

WHO USES IT · WHAT IT REPLACES

Used by hardened deployments and privacy distros for exploit-mitigating memory allocation; the open allocator adopted by GrapheneOS-class systems.

WHERE IT SITS — REALM TOP 8 BY STARS (▶ = THIS TOOL)



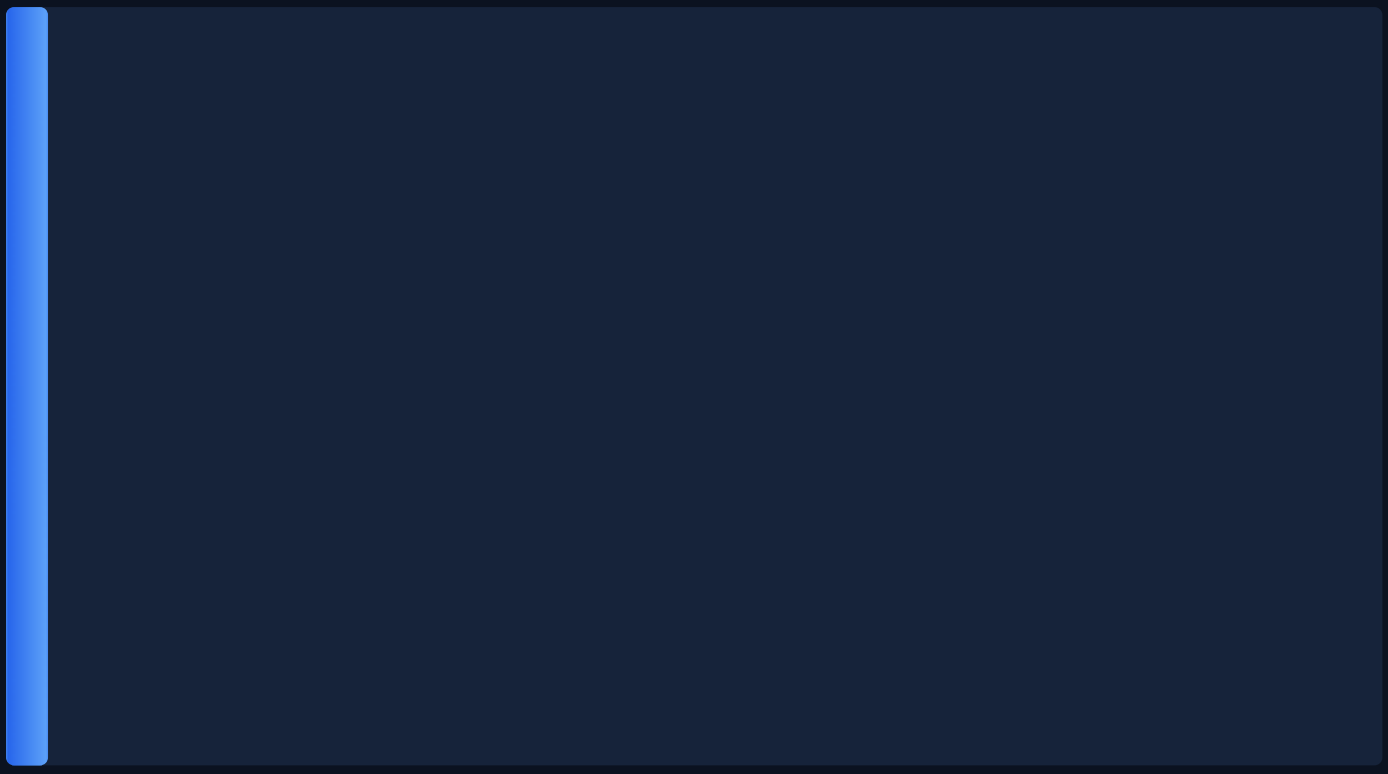
8	167	52	yes
YEARS ON GITHUB	FORKS (REUSE)	OPEN ISSUES	2026 MOMENTUM

14 keyFinder

github.com/momenbasel/keyFinder

ACTIVE 2026

star weight vs realm #1



★ 725	GITHUB STARS
127	FORKS
2026-07	LAST PUSH
2019	FIRST DEVELOPED
MIT	LICENSE
JavaScript	LANGUAGE

THEIR CLAIM — AS THE PROJECT STATES IT

"Passive API key and secret discovery browser extension for Chrome and Firefox. 80+ detection patterns, zero config."

CURATOR'S NOTE — WHY IT EARNS A PLACE

passively discovers leaked API keys and secrets in web pages during browsing.

WHO USES IT · WHAT IT REPLACES

Used by forensic analysts locating crypto key material in memory images; the niche free utility for DFIR work.

WHERE IT SITS — REALM TOP 8 BY STARS (▶ = THIS TOOL)



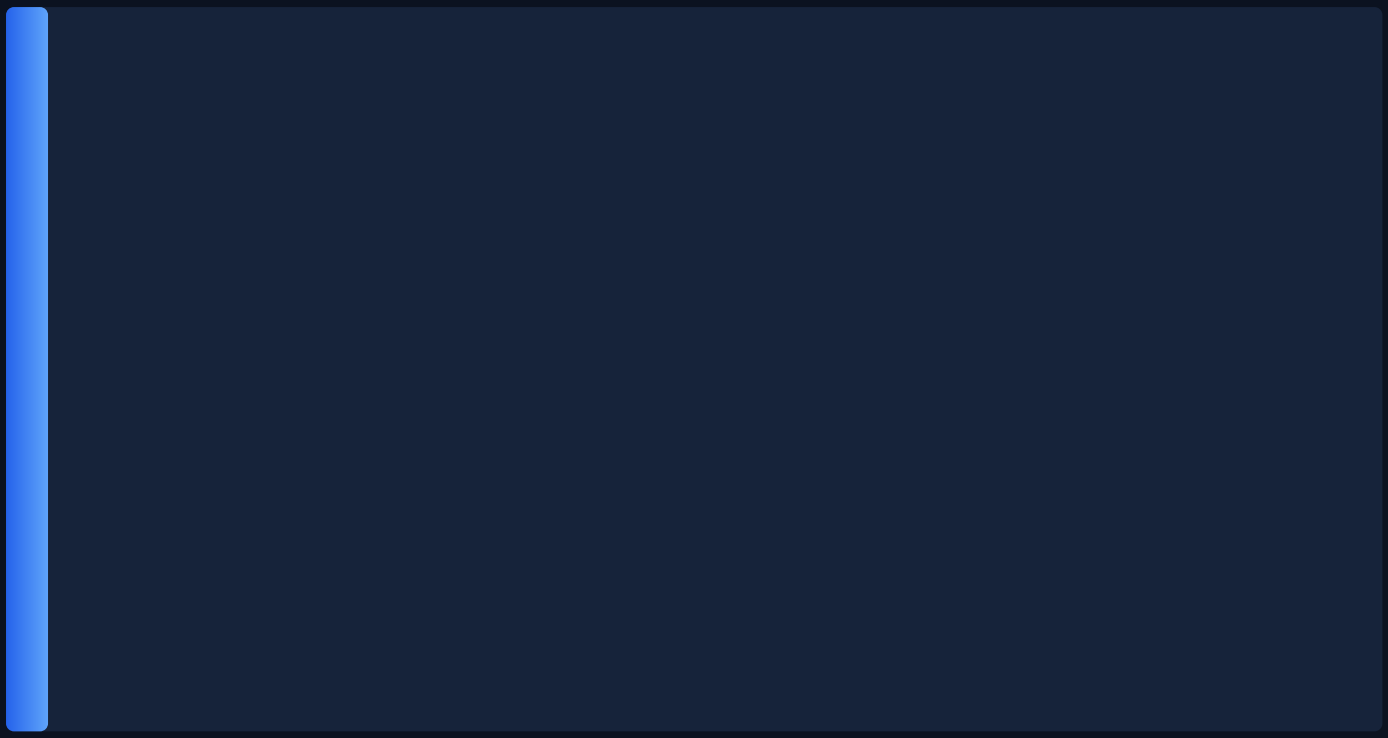
7	127	5	yes
YEARS ON GITHUB	FORKS (REUSE)	OPEN ISSUES	2026 MOMENTUM

15 Retraced (BoxyHQ)

ACTIVE 2026

github.com/retracedhq/retraced

star weight vs realm #1



★ 451	GITHUB STARS
35	FORKS
2026-08	LAST PUSH
2016	FIRST DEVELOPED
Apache-2.0	LICENSE
TypeScript	LANGUAGE

THEIR CLAIM — AS THE PROJECT STATES IT

"🔥 A fully open source audit logs service and embeddable UI easily deployed to your own Kubernetes cluster. Brought to you by replicated.com and boxyhq.com 🚀"

CURATOR'S NOTE — WHY IT EARNS A PLACE

open-source audit-log API: compliant, tamper-evident activity records for your SaaS.

WHO USES IT · WHAT IT REPLACES

Used by SaaS builders adding compliance-grade audit logging; the open-source alternative to commercial audit-log services.

WHERE IT SITS — REALM TOP 8 BY STARS (▶ = THIS TOOL)



10	35	32	yes
YEARS ON GITHUB	FORKS (REUSE)	OPEN ISSUES	2026 MOMENTUM

16 Databunker

databunker.org/

WEB / STANDALONE

—

NOT GITHUB-HOSTED · WEBSITE / STANDALONE

THEIR CLAIM — AS THE PROJECT STATES IT

“Databunker”

CURATOR'S NOTE — WHY IT EARNS A PLACE

encrypted personal-data vault: API-first storage for PII with built-in privacy compliance.

WHO USES IT · WHAT IT REPLACES

Used by backend teams storing customer PII encrypted and auditable; the open-source alternative to commercial customer-data vaults.

17 MAT2

0xacab.org/jvoisin/mat2

WEB / STANDALONE

—

NOT GITHUB-HOSTED · WEBSITE / STANDALONE

THEIR CLAIM — AS THE PROJECT STATES IT

“MAT2”

CURATOR'S NOTE — WHY IT EARNS A PLACE

Metadata Anonymisation Toolkit v2: strips hidden metadata from documents, images and more.

WHO USES IT · WHAT IT REPLACES

Used by journalists and privacy-conscious users stripping metadata from documents; the free alternative to commercial redaction suites.

04 Realm Directory

17 curated entries · A–Z

- age
- Bitwarden
- Databunker
- detect-secrets
- gitleaks
- hardened_malloc
- hashcat
- HashiCorp Vault
- John the Ripper
- KeePassXC
- keyFinder
- LaZagne
- MAT2
- noseyparker
- Retraced (BoxyHQ)
- SOPS
- trufflehog